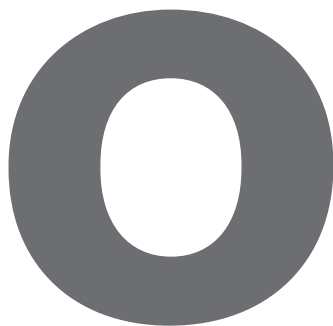




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**ON APRIL 1**, T.V. Mohandas Pai was stuck at the Bengaluru airport. The former Infosys CFO and Chairman of Manipal Global Education and Aarin Capital Partners was scheduled to travel to Ahmedabad on a Vistara flight at 10:30 am, but the departure was pushed back to 12 pm. With no prior intimation from the airline, Pai took to social media platform X to vent his frustration: “Why did they not message the delay? Terrible service, no announcement, no clarity.” Vistara, in its reply, refuted Pai’s claims of not sending out communications, saying it had communicated the delay to the “registered contact details present on the PNR” and said that the flight “was delayed due to operational reasons”.

Pai wasn’t the only one. Several Vistara passengers travelling in early April found their flights being cancelled—many at the last minute—as the airline, which held a 9.8% share of domestic passenger traffic as of March, cancelled dozens of flights. According to estimates, Vistara cancelled 80 flights on April 1, while 190 were delayed. Together, these formed some 75% of the airline’s average daily flights.

Trouble had been brewing at Vistara—which has a fleet size of around 70 aircraft and flies to 50 destinations, domestic and in-

ternational—since early March. There were repeated flight cancellations at the airline, a joint venture between the Tata group and Singapore Airlines, which the management blamed on unfavourable weather conditions, traffic congestion and other unforeseen factors. Industry watchers say the key reason came to the fore in end-March: a disagreement over new payment terms—in the run-up to its merger with sister airline Air India—between pilots and the management. As pilots went on unplanned leave, the airline had no option but to cancel scheduled flights.

Vistara is not alone. From pilot shortages, lack of back-up staff and limited infrastructure to low turnaround time of aircraft and tight cost efficiency model of operations, most leading airlines in India are operating under severe stress, often resulting in abrupt flight cancellations, unannounced delays, and poor customer service. The grounding of aircraft due to Pratt & Whitney engine issues in recent months by leading players like IndiGo has meant a lower number of flight-worthy aircraft, while passenger traffic has steadily risen since the pandemic (domestic traffic bounced back to 136 million in FY23).

According to aviation expert Jitender Bhargava, a former executive director of Air India, the

above-mentioned issues have put further strain on a system that was already stretched. “Factors that are beyond one’s control—like the fog in winter months—have disrupted operations. But when multiple flights are delayed and it is clear to the airlines that their daily schedule is already impacted, then not informing the passengers in advance is not acceptable. This happens due to a lack of coordination between the airlines and the airports,” he says.

Latest data from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) shows that weather-related issues resulted in 58.9% of the flights cancelled during February, while technical snags were responsible for nearly 20% of the cancellations. If fog is the biggest pain point in the winter months, technical snags take the crown as temperatures rise. In March, for instance, technical snags caused nearly 38.6% of the cancellations, while weather-related issues contributed to 15.6% of them.

At the core of weather-related issues is the dense fog that envelops North India in winter. Experts say the disruptions occur due to lack of infrastructure and resources. To land and take off in fog, airlines need to have adequate pilots trained for such weather. “But how does an airline send its pilots for training? Since most of them are



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DURING AN EARNINGS CALL IN FEBRUARY